“No strength,” she said.

“Take it slowly. I’m helping today.”

The two women worked through lunch. Léa didn’t mind skipping her meal. But she worried that with Maria’s poor health, she needed to eat. Her face was already too thin, and her cheeks hollowed out. During the afternoon break, she went to the café and ordered a slice of coffee cake. Bringing it back in a brown paper bag to the factory floor, she intended on slipping it into Maria’s bag for her to eat later. But when Léa arrived at her workstation, Maria’s head was on the table, arms hanging at her sides.

“Maria,” she whispered, shaking her shoulder. “Wake up.”

“I can’t . . .” she muttered.

The Meister saw and came over. “Get back to work,” he commanded.

Léa put her hand on Maria’s forehead; it was hot to the touch. “She has a fever. She should go to the sick bay.”

“She’s already behind on her production quota for the day.” He put his hands on his hips. “Lazy Polish . . . I know her game and it—”

“Let me bring her to the sick bay.”

“Now you want to go off and be absent too.” He crossed his arms at his chest. “*Nein*.”

Léa remembered all she’d seen that first day in Glashütte—how they’d humiliated the Polish women by shaving them, fearing they carried diseases that would spread through the town. If she could appeal to that irrational fear now, it might get Maria the care she deserved. “What if it’s tuberculosis or typhoid?”

His eyes flicked toward Maria and then back at Léa. She hoped he was calculating the risk of missing production quotas versus exposing himself and the other women to disease. His stubby fingers tapped the sides of his arms. He was clearly getting sufficient food.

“Take her to the sick bay,” he ordered, cursing them both under his breath. “But come back immediately.”

Léa lifted Maria from the stool. She was light, too light. Léa tried to hold her gently so as not to squeeze her ribs.

“Where . . . we going?” Maria whispered.

“To the sick bay. It’s not far.” She turned to the Meister. “Please write a pass. If we’re stopped, she’ll be in trouble.”

He grunted and went to his desk. Léa wasn’t taking any chances. She